

Comprehensive Guide to Cricket Rules

1. Match Formats

Cricket has evolved into three distinct international formats, each requiring vastly different strategies, stamina levels, and skill sets.

Format	Duration	Overs Limit	Characteristics
Test Cricket	Up to 5 Days	Unlimited (Two innings per team)	The pinnacle of the sport. Played in white clothing with a red ball. Focuses on endurance, technique, and strategic slow-play.
One Day International (ODI)	Approx. 8 Hours	50 Overs per side	Played with colored clothing and a white ball. Balances aggressive batting with measured, economical bowling.
Twenty20 (T20)	Approx. 3 Hours	20 Overs per side	High-octane, fast-paced format. Emphasis is entirely on power-hitting, rapid scoring, and innovative bowling variations.

2. The Pitch and Field Apparatus

The game centers around the 22-yard pitch. At each end are the wickets (three wooden stumps topped with two bails). Painted white lines define the creases:

- **Popping Crease:** Drawn 4 feet in front of the stumps. The batter must have some part of their bat or body grounded behind this line to be "safe." Bowlers must plant their front foot behind this line to bowl a legal delivery.
- **Return Creases:** The side boundaries for the bowler. The bowler's back foot must land within these lines.

3. Scoring Mechanics

The objective is to score more runs than the opposition. Runs are accumulated through active batting and penalty extras.

- **Running between wickets:** After striking the ball, the two batsmen run to opposite ends of the pitch. Each successful crossing scores one run.
- **Boundaries:** If the struck ball hits the ground and rolls over the outer field boundary, it automatically scores four (4) runs. If the ball clears the boundary without bouncing, it scores six (6) runs.

Extras (Penalty Runs): Runs awarded to the batting team not credited to the batsman.

- **Wide:** Ball bowled too far from the batter to reach (1 run + extra ball).

- **No-Ball:** Illegal delivery, usually overstepping the crease (1 run + extra ball, often a Free Hit).
- **Byes & Leg Byes:** Runs scored without the ball touching the bat (it misses the batter or hits their pads).

4. Methods of Dismissal

A fielding team must dismiss ten batsmen to end an innings (since batsmen operate in pairs, one is always left "not out"). There are several common ways to get out:

- **Bowled:** The bowler delivers the ball, it bypasses the batter, and hits the stumps, dislodging the bails.
- **Caught:** The batter hits the ball with the bat (or glove attached to the bat) and a fielder catches it before it touches the ground.
- **LBW (Leg Before Wicket):** The ball strikes the batter's body (usually the leg) and the umpire judges that the ball would have gone on to hit the stumps if the leg hadn't been there.
- **Run Out:** While the batsmen are attempting a run, a fielder throws the ball and hits the stumps before the running batter grounds their bat behind the popping crease.
- **Stumped:** The batter steps out of their crease to hit the ball, misses, and the wicket-keeper catches the ball and dislodges the bails before the batter can get back behind the line.
- **Hit Wicket:** The batter accidentally knocks down their own stumps with their bat or body while attempting to play a shot.

5. Fielding Positions and Restrictions

The captain places nine fielders (plus the bowler and wicketkeeper) strategically to prevent runs or catch the ball. Positions have unique names like Slip, Gully, Point, Cover, Mid-off, Mid-on, Square Leg, and Fine Leg.

In limited-overs cricket (ODI and T20), "Powerplays" enforce strict fielding restrictions. For example, during the first 6 overs of a T20 match, a maximum of two fielders are allowed outside the 30-yard inner circle. This encourages aggressive batting early in the innings. In the final phases, up to five fielders may be allowed in the deep to defend boundaries.

6. Umpiring and the DRS System

Two on-field umpires enforce the laws. One stands behind the non-striker's stumps, and the other at square leg. International matches utilize the Decision Review System (DRS), allowing teams to challenge on-field decisions using ball-tracking technology (Hawk-Eye), edge-detection microphones (Snicko), and thermal imaging (Hot Spot).